

FACILITATION SKILLS SERIES

Running Effective Remote Workshops

Techniques for planning, energizing and closing productive online sessions

What this session covers

01 | Why remote workshops fail without deliberate design

02 | What a workshop actually is — and is not

03 | The three pillars of engagement

04 | A five-stage facilitation process

05 | Roles and how the elements connect

06 | Choosing formats and keeping everyone oriented

In-person habits do not transfer

The same agenda that works in a meeting room often collapses online.

In the room

- Energy is visible and self-correcting
- Side conversations surface ideas
- Whiteboards invite spontaneous input
- Breaks happen naturally

On a call

- Silence hides disengagement
- One voice dominates the channel
- Screens encourage passive watching
- Fatigue builds without movement

What is a workshop?

DEFINITION

Workshop

“A structured working session in which a group actively produces a concrete outcome together, rather than receiving information passively.”

- The outcome — a decision, a plan, a prototype — is agreed before the session starts
- If participants could be replaced by an email, it is a meeting, not a workshop

Three pillars of remote engagement

Participation

Every attendee contributes something visible in the first ten minutes.

- Round-robin openers
- Shared canvases
- Small breakout groups

Rhythm

Alternate intensity: never more than fifteen minutes in one mode.

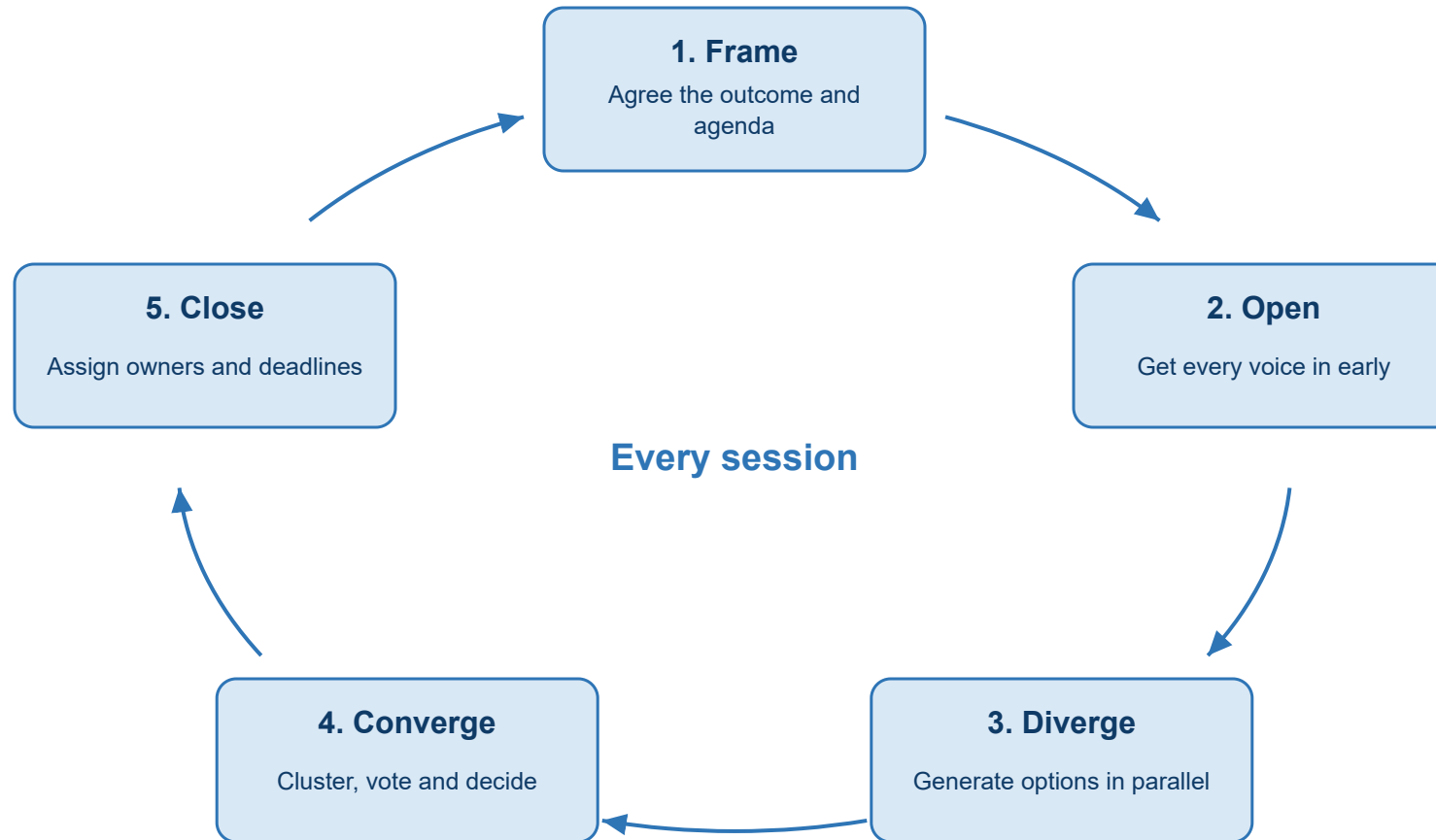
- Timeboxed exercises
- Movement breaks
- Energy checks

Clarity

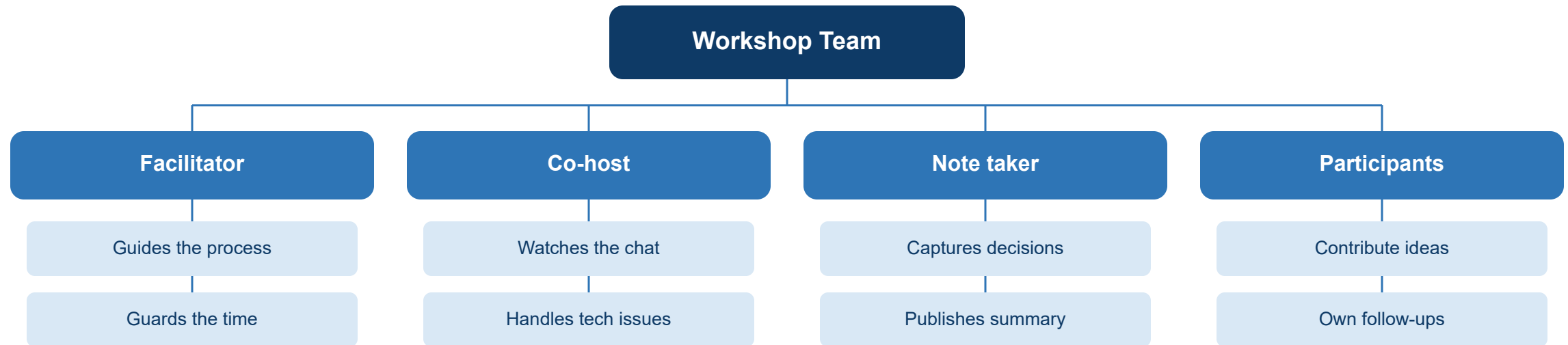
At any moment everyone knows what is being asked of them.

- One instruction at a time
- Visible timers
- Written prompts

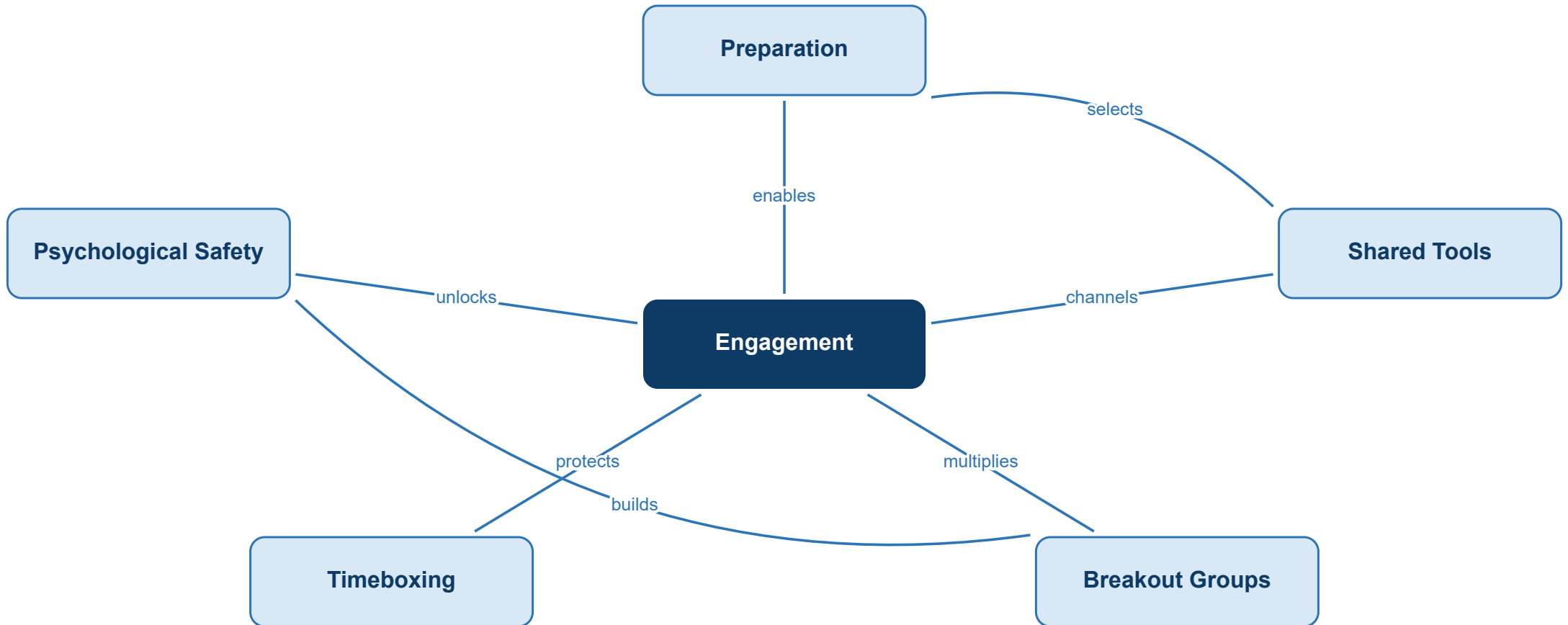
The facilitation cycle



Who does what in a workshop



How the elements connect



Live collaboration versus async preparation

Live collaboration

- Best for decisions and creative leaps
- Builds shared ownership fast
- Expensive: everyone at the same time
- Energy management is critical

VS

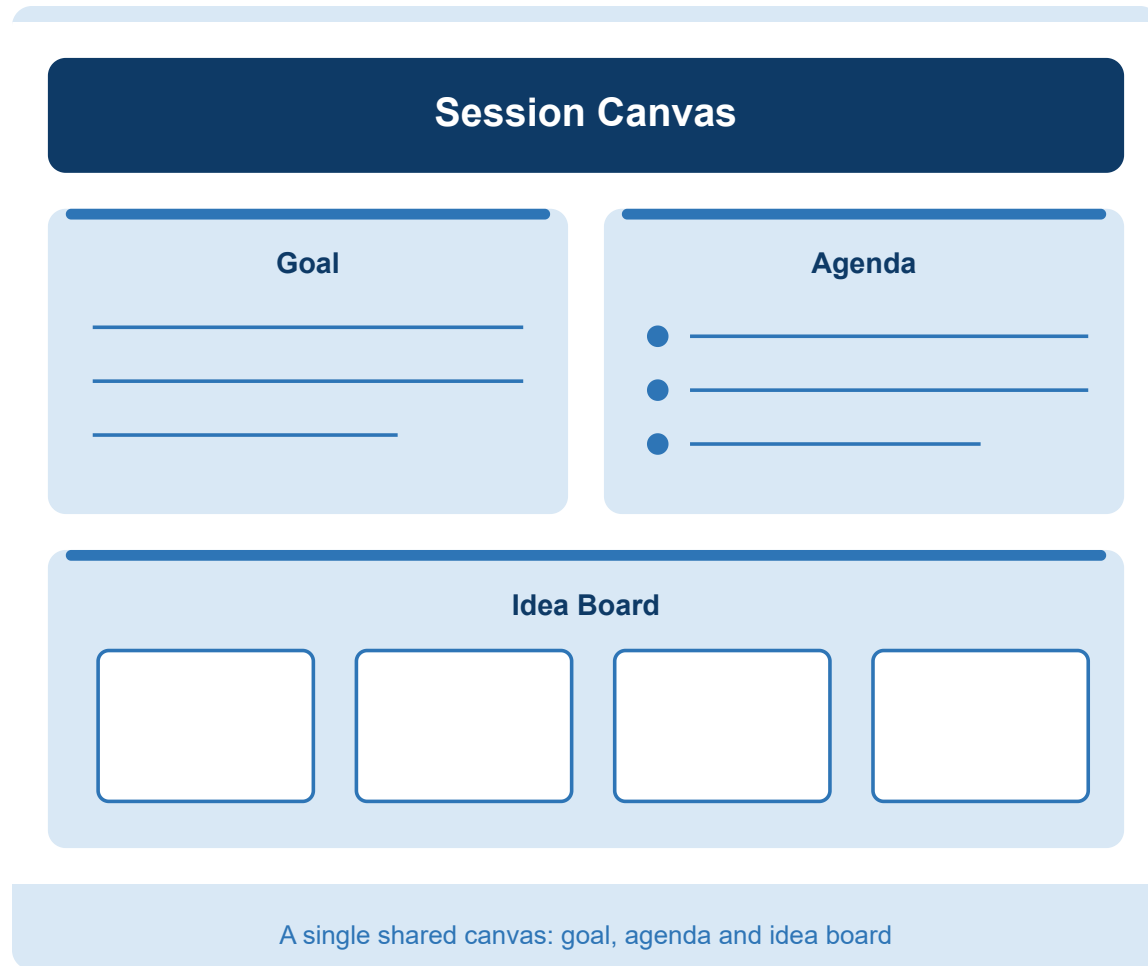
Async preparation

- Best for research and individual input
- Gives quiet thinkers equal weight
- Cheap: everyone at their own pace
- Needs crisp written instructions

Choosing a format for each goal

Goal	Best format	Group size	Typical length
Generate many ideas	Silent brainstorm, then clustering	4–8	30 min
Make a decision	Options review with dot voting	3–6	45 min
Align on a plan	Milestone mapping on a timeline	4–10	60 min
Gather feedback	Structured critique rounds	3–8	30 min
Build team trust	Paired interviews and share-back	6–12	45 min

One canvas keeps everyone oriented



- Participants never ask "where are we?" — the canvas shows it
- The goal stays visible while ideas accumulate below
- Everything lives in one place after the session
 - No lost sticky notes
 - Summary is one export away

Key takeaway

A remote workshop succeeds by design, not by chance — structure participation, protect the rhythm, and make every instruction impossible to misunderstand.

Design for contribution, not attendance

Change the mode every fifteen minutes

Close with owners and deadlines